

Call-A-Career

BPOs pay well, and the job is boring. Is there more to the picture than just that?

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Business Process Outsourcing (BPO) has been around for about half a decade, and has been steadily gaining ground in India. According to the NASSCOM Strategic Review 2006, employment in BPOs, which comes under the ITES (IT-Enabled Services) sector, was a good 3,16,000 in fiscal 2005, beating the 2,97,000 figure for the IT services sector. These numbers, according to NASSCOM, are expected to go up to 4,09,000 in FY 2006. Revenues from this category are expected to be \$7.2 billion (Rs 32,400 crore).

Does this imply air-conditioned workplaces, transport to work, meals and snacks on the house, and lifestyle perks for the 2.5 million fresh graduates that are churned out every year across the country?

The Quality Boom

The BPO boom in the past five years has provided a window of career opportunity for many fresh graduates. And jobs at BPOs are no longer just about informing a Mr Jones in far-away New Jersey that his power bill is overdue or updating a Mrs Smith's name in the records because she just had a divorce.

Take the case of Chennai-based Congruent Solutions, which administers retirement benefits for US citizens. Their process comprises 20 different activities, and it's usually a Chartered Accountant who heads a team. In reference to the terms used for businesses such as this, its president and co-founder Bala J Raman says, "There is a thin line between labels such as KPO (Knowledge Process Outsourcing) and BPO. I would call our firm a Business Process, albeit a high-end one.

On the eligibility front, "An M.Com. or a graduation in actuarial science is our only requirement. Of course, the candidate should clear our aptitude tests and interviews." Raman continues, "One's qualification is, of course, a consideration at the start. But after that, growth is a matter of how well an employee uses his skills: analysis of a situation, the ability to anticipate roadblocks, and put corrective measures in place." As an example, he cites the case of an employee who rose to a Team Leader position in just two years, although he was not a qualified Chartered Accountant.

Do You Speak English?

A large majority of BPOs are still at the lower end of the process hierarchy. Epicenter Technologies, Mumbai, is one of the largest BPOs that provides collection services. Sunita Bhuyan, training head and spokesperson, says, "We look for only two qualifications while recruiting freshers; they have to speak English, and they should be 'smart'".

Training strategies in this sector have evolved. According to Bhuyan, what used to be all about voice and accent

Illustration Rohit Chandwaskar